

WAHHABISM A form of Islam named after Muhammed Ibn Abdul Wahhab (1703–91), who reintroduced Shariah law to the Arabian Peninsula. Shariah imposes religious rules on every aspect of life, including politics, sexuality, and social issues. Wahhabism became the formal doctrine of Saudi Arabia in 1800.

curriculum, discarded much of Shariah law, and discouraged Iranians from obeying the call to prayer or from making pilgrimages. The result was ever-greater social division. While the upper classes became more secular and Western in their outlook, the masses—who were forced to pay heavy taxes to fund the Shah’s reforms—remained impoverished and deeply religious.

World War II and after

Reza Shah offered support to the Nazis in World War II, hoping that Germany would help Iran to rid itself of British influence. The Shah’s Nazi sympathies threatened Allied access to Iranian oil, so when Germany invaded Russia in



Iran hostage crisis

Student militants burn a US flag on the roof of the US embassy in Tehran during the early days of the 1979 hostage crisis, when embassy staff were held hostage by protesters.

Protest against the Shah

The corrupt and brutal regime of Mohammed Reza Shah produced waves of demonstration during 1978.

Protesters thronged the streets clutching pictures of the exiled religious cleric Ayatollah Khomeini. In December, the Shah abandoned his attempts to hold on to power and fled Iran, leaving the way open for Khomeini to return to Iran.

1941, British and Russian troops invaded Iran. Reza Shah was deposed and replaced by his son, Mohammed Reza. Resentment of Western interference deepened.

In the postwar years, students spearheaded a backlash against secularism and corruption. In 1951, political unrest forced the Shah to loosen his grip on power and appoint Mohammed Mossadeq as Prime Minister. Mossadeq soon nationalized the assets of the Anglo-Iranian Oil Company. With the Cold War at its height (see pp.406–07), fears of growing Soviet influence in the Middle East led Britain and the US to block sales of Iranian oil. Iran’s economy descended into crisis.

In 1953, Western intelligence services supported a military coup, which restored absolute power to Mohammed Reza Shah. The Shah’s rule became increasingly dictatorial. While his security police ran a terror campaign against dissenters and many of the rural poor were suffering from malnutrition, the Shah led a lavish life on oil revenues, which grew from an annual \$285 million in 1960 to \$18,523 million by the mid-1970s.

Islamic revolution

In Iran’s mosques, the teachings of an exiled ayatollah (high-ranking Muslim cleric) were gaining ground. Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini had been exiled in 1964 for calling the Shah a “puppet” of the West. His teachings called for an end to the Shah’s reign, insisting that only clerics should rule, since they are the true representatives of God.

By 1978, Khomeini had widespread support. Pro-Khomeini demonstrations were brutally suppressed, but unrest still spread from city to city as clerics, nationalists, and moderates united in a struggle for change. Although martial law was imposed, many troops refused

to shoot at protesters. In December, the US tried to persuade the Shah to liberalize his regime, but revolution was now inevitable. The Shah and his family fled Iran on January 16, 1979.

Khomeini returned to Iran on February 1, 1979. After initial fighting between political factions, a popular referendum voted for the creation of an Islamic republic.

A new constitution named Khomeini as Iran’s supreme leader, clergy were appointed to run state institutions, and Shariah law was introduced.

The Iran Hostage Crisis

On October 22, 1979, US president Jimmy Carter allowed the Shah to enter the US for cancer treatment. Outraged Iranian students, who wanted the Shah



Triumphant return

After 14 years in exile, Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini arrived in Tehran to an ecstatic reception. Khomeini rapidly set about creating a clerical state under Shariah Law.

Since the Iranian Revolution, the world has seen tensions between Muslim groups, as well as continued hostility in some Islamic factions toward Western regimes.

THE MANY STRANDS OF ISLAM

Khomeini’s traditionalism is not the only view of Islam. Like Christianity, Islam has a number of different interpretations and several distinct denominations, or groups. **Sunni** Muslims form the largest group, comprising about 85 percent of the world’s Muslims; **Shia** form approximately 15 percent. Some Muslims follow a mystical form of Islam called **Sufism**. All denominations have a slightly different understanding of the **Qur’an**, the central religious text of Islam.

IRAN AFTER KHOMEINI

After the death of Ayatollah Khomeini in 1989 largely came to nothing, hopes for a moderation in the Islamic regime rose with the election of the reformist cleric **Mohammed Khatami** as president in 1997.

However, his attempts at reform were hampered by political conservatives, hard-line clerics, and the state security apparatus, and in 2005 he was replaced by the ultraconservative nationalist, **Mahmoud**



THE POWER OF FAITH

Ahmadijehad. Since the 1980s Iran has been accused of meddling in Syria to support the Islamist Hezbollah militia, and favoring Shia factions in post-Saddam Iraq. It has also pursued the **development of a nuclear program** despite fierce opposition from other countries that fear this is aimed at producing nuclear weapons.

returned to Iran to face trial, invaded the US embassy in Tehran, taking 63 Americans hostage. Although the Shah died less than a year later, Khomeini refused to release the hostages, holding 52 Americans captive for 444 days. The crisis finally concluded with the signing of the Algiers Accord in January 1981.

Khomeini’s defiance of America was a key factor in Western governments’ support for Saddam Hussein’s invasion of Iran in 1980, and their willingness to provide him with weapons during the eight-year-long Iran–Iraq war (see p.468). By the time Khomeini died in June 1989, Iran was a well-established Islamic state.

“In Islam, the legislative **power and competence** to establish laws belong exclusively to God.”

AYATOLLAH RUHOLLAH KHOMEINI